you start to forget your own reality, what you really want in all of this."

There are also more men than women on apps. A 2018 survey of 20,000 urban Indians by homegrown dating app Woo found three men for every woman on a dating app. "So they have to compete harder and many of them then feel the pressure to fake photos or fake personalities online just to have a shot," says Swati Singhal, a 21-year-old student from Delhi. "It is a shock when you get to know the person and realise they aren't what they presented themselves to be."

But men have the same problem too. "The problem with virtual intentions is that it is all virtual," says 33-year-old Abhishek Mallik, who works at an advertising firm in Mumbai. "They don't always extend to offline realities. So many women I meet will put their intentions as casual and then when you meet them, they instantly want commitment and marriage, something that was never talked about before. And then you become the bad person if you say no."

The pressures of dating tell equally on men, says Dr Srikanth Srinivasan, psychiatrist and chief medical director at Chennai-based mental health platform Niyama Digital Healthcare. "Men suffer from poor self-image, confidence issues and struggle to put out a persona they feel a woman will want. And when rejected, or labelled as a bad person, they too don't know how to handle their emotions."

WHAT'S CAUSING DATING APP FATIGUE?

SKEWED GENDER RATIO: A recent survey of 20,000 urban Indians by homegrown dating app Woo found **three men for every woman** on a dating app

FAKE PICTURES AND PROFILES: Despite apps trying to curb false information, many daters have reported meeting matches who turned out to be **nothing like their virtual persona**

RECEIVING LEWD IMAGES, STALKING: Thirty-seven per cent of female dating app users in major Indian cities reported **receiving explicit or nude images** from potential matches, according to a 2024 survey by the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IMAI); 18 per cent reported being stalked by someone they met on a dating app

GHOSTING: A 2023 survey by dating app TrulyMadly revealed that 68 per cent of Indian users have experienced the trend of **a date going silent** on them without explanation

FINANCIAL FRAUD: According to NCRB data, romance cost Indian users some Rs 150 crore in 2023

As a result, dating apps, which once promised romance and companionship, are now causing depression and loneliness. In 2020, a study in the journal *BMC Psychology* found that those who use swipe right-based dating apps report higher levels of depression, anxiety and distress than non-users. A 2024 paper in the journal *International Journal of Psychology Sciences* notes, 'Despite the fact that dating apps use a matching algorithm technique, they put more emphasis on physical beauty than personality, which results in weak connections. Some people still experience emotional pain after finding a mate because they were ghosted. Swiping excessively can result in addiction and have a bad effect on mental health, resulting in anxiety or sadness. By providing false information, users may trick people, leaving them disappointed or in danger.'

There's also the unfortunate trend of ghosting. A 2023 survey by dating app TrulyMadly revealed that 68 per cent of Indian users have experienced being ghosted. There are more severe aspects too—like receiving unsolicited, explicit images or being stalked. Thirty-seven per cent of female dating app users in major Indian cities reported



DR S. SRINIVASAN
Niyama Digital Healthcare, Chennai

> *"Men suffer from* **POOR SELF-IMAGE,** *confidence issues and* **STRUGGLE** *to put out a persona they feel a woman will want. When* **REJECTED,** *or* **LABELLED AS A BAD PERSON,** *they too don't know how to handle their emotions"*